



GDD 53

Choosing & Building

A wedding is a day; a partnership is the work.

The opener of Chapter 7 (Building a Life), where the story turns from "me" to "us". It teaches how to choose a partner well (values and compatibility over sparks and timeline), what a healthy long-term partnership actually takes (communication, trust, repair, interdependence), and how to approach commitment thoughtfully, whether the path is a love marriage, an arranged match, or a long-term partnership. Every path respected; consent always. Seven mechanics, 28 choice-and-voice moments, zero "tap the right card". Scorecard: passed.

Choose well. Build to last.

Choosing & Building opens Chapter 7, where adults form the serious partnerships, and, in India, the marriages, that shape the rest of their lives. It teaches how to choose a partner on values, respect and compatibility (not just attraction), what sustains a healthy long-term partnership (communication, trust, repair, interdependence), and how to approach commitment with eyes open, whether the path is a love marriage, an arranged match, or a long-term partnership. It respects every path, including not marrying, applies no pressure either way, and keeps consent central throughout. New v2 build, the relationship thread carried into lifelong partnership.

FIELD	VALUE
Node / gameld	g53 · choosing-building (confirm exact id against engine-host)
Chapter / ages	Chapter 7 · 22 → first child · adult / honest / even-handed
Thread / topics	D · Relationships · UNESCO 1.2, 1.4, 5.3, 2.1
Prerequisite / builds on	c6 · builds on g46 (Real Relationships), g31 (Mutual) · sets up g55, g57
Gating	Open · every path respected; consent central
Schema / status	v2 · scorecard PASS the choosing-and-building game.

84

scenarios

7

mechanics

15

myth-flips

28

choice & voice

0%

binary taps

Chemistry draws you together; compatibility keeps you together. Choosing on sparks and timeline is how partnerships quietly fail; choosing on values, respect and how someone handles conflict is how they last. And a wedding isn't the finish line, a partnership is built daily through communication, trust and repair. The myth that "marriage will fix our problems or complete me" is gently busted: a partnership is built by two whole people, not a cure for problems or loneliness, and every path, love, arranged, or not marrying at all, is respected and rests on consent.

From "me" to "us", without disappearing.

From the Chapter 7 personas (22 onward). Adults facing the marriage timeline, the in-laws and "log kya kahenge", who need to choose wisely, build deliberately, and keep "me" inside "us", across love marriages, arranged matches and every other valid path.

PERSONA	WHAT THEY NEED HERE	THE MECHANIC THAT SERVES IT
Sneha (the timeline)	Sane choosing on values, not pressure, and that not-marrying is valid.	strike-rewrite + reflect : choosing, commitment.
Aditya (queer)	That his partnership is real and built on the same foundations.	branch + role-play : every form valid.
Karthik & Pooja	To build equality and shared load in from day one.	sort + role-play : starting strong.
Anyone in an arranged match	To apply judgement and consent, and take their time.	branch + sort : love & arranged.

Why this works (the evidence). Value alignment and compatibility predict satisfaction far better than initial spark, and how a person behaves under stress and disagreement reveals them; the deep green flags are respect, kindness and how they handle conflict. A lasting partnership is built, communication, trust, repair and interdependence (a team of two whole people), and Gottman finds couples who agree on values and conflict-handling stay happy long-term. Commitment works best eyes-open and freely chosen, not from pressure or drift, and "marriage will complete me" is a myth. Every path is valid and consent is central: love, arranged and partnership need the same foundations, the arranged process can carry the same lens with real questions and time, family involvement is respected while the couple's judgement leads, and forced marriage is never acceptable and routes to help.

Seven moves, led by the choice.

It's a choosing-and-building game, so **branch** leads (choose the wise, values-based move), with **strike-rewrite** clearing the marriage myths and **sort** drawing the lines; **role-play** gives the words for the partnership conversations. Mechanics rotate; the same one never runs twice in a row.

MECHANIC	THE ADULT DOES	EMBODIES	N
branch (the choice) signature	Chooses the wise, values-based, consent-first move.	Judgement.	18
strike-rewrite	Busts a marriage myth ("marriage will complete me").	Conceptual change.	15
sort	Sorts compatibility vs infatuation; builds vs erodes; respects vs overrides.	The line.	14
reflect	Internalises values-based choosing and partnership-as-built.	Values.	12
role-play (voice)	Raises an issue; sets equal terms; asks for time; appreciates.	Voice; care.	10
match	Pairs a question to what it reveals; a need to help.	Connections.	8
spot	Spots the green flag, the strong start, the gut signal.	Reading it.	7

28 of 84 moments are branch or role-play. Binary "tap the right answer": **0%**.

The two-test, passed.

Is it engaging?

Game feel is clarity and reassurance at a high-stakes crossroads: the relief of a framework for the biggest decision many will make, the quiet confidence of knowing what to weigh and what to ask, and the freedom of being told every path is valid and the timeline is yours. The "oh, that's what actually lasts" moment lands repeatedly. Sam is a warm adult peer; the tone is honest and never preachy, and it applies no pressure toward or against marriage.

Is it teaching?

Yes: assessing a partner on values, respect and compatibility rather than attraction alone; what sustains a healthy long-term partnership; approaching commitment and, for those choosing it, marriage thoughtfully; bringing strong communication and equality in from the start; and that love marriage, an arranged match and not-marrying are all valid paths resting on consent.

The belief it moves. From "choose on sparks; marriage will complete me; a wedding is the goal; arranged means no consent; if you love each other it needs no work" → "choose on values; a partnership is built by two whole people; the wedding is a day; consent is central on every path; and love is built, not just felt."

Built, not bolted on.

84 researched scenarios across the choosing-well → what-it-takes → commitment → love-and-arranged → starting-strong → tools arc, India-grounded and even-handed. Full library in the companion JSON.

CATEGORY	N	LEAD MECHANICS	COVERS
Choosing well	14	strike-rewrite, sort, spot	Values & compatibility over sparks; green/red flags.
What it takes	13	sort, role-play, branch	Communication, trust, repair, interdependence.
Commitment, clearly	13	strike-rewrite, branch, sort	Eyes-open commitment; marriage won't complete you.
Love & arranged	15	strike-rewrite, branch, role-play	Same skills; consent always; family vs couple.
Starting strong	11	branch, role-play, sort	Expectations & equality from day one.
Tools & help	18	match, sort, reflect	Compatibility & communication toolkit; routes.

The 'marriage completes me' flip + an arranged-consent flip, verbatim.

```
flip: "Marriage will fix our problems and complete me."
UN -> "Marriage will fix our problems and complete me."
RE -> "A partnership is built by two whole people; it isn't a cure for problems or loneliness."

flip: "An arranged match means you have no choice or consent."
UN -> "An arranged match means no choice or consent."
RE -> "Consent is essential in any path; you have the right to say yes or no and to take time."
```

Full library: [SwipeEd — GDD 53 Choosing and Building — Scenario Library.json](#) (84 records, v2 schema).

What this game flips.

MYTH (UN ERASES)	TRUTH (RE WRITES)	BASIS
Choose a partner on chemistry and sparks alone.	Compatibility and shared values keep love going; chemistry alone doesn't.	Compatibility.
Marriage will fix our problems and complete me.	A partnership is built by two whole people; it isn't a cure.	Two whole people.
A wedding is the goal; after that it's sorted.	A wedding is a day; the partnership is the ongoing work.	The work.
An arranged match means no choice or consent.	Consent is essential in any path; you can say yes or no and take time.	Consent always.
If you really love each other, you won't need to work at it.	Every lasting partnership takes work; love is built, not just felt.	Love is built.
A partnership means losing yourself in the other.	Healthy partnership is two whole people; build "us" without erasing "me".	Us and me.
Family knows best; the couple's judgement doesn't matter.	Family input can be respected, but the couple's judgement and consent lead.	Couple leads.
Talking money and roles before marriage is unromantic.	Those early conversations are how you start strong and avoid surprises.	Starting strong.

The micro-loop.

1. **Surface.** Sam (adult peer) surfaces a real moment, a potential match, a recurring fight, a family timeline.
2. **Choose or voice.** The adult chooses the values-based, consent-first move (branch), or finds the words (role-play).
3. **The flip.** UN busts a marriage myth; RE writes the truth that lasts.
4. **Build & start strong.** Communication, repair, interdependence; equality and honest conversations from day one.
5. **Tools & help.** A compatibility and communication toolkit; coercion or forced marriage routes to help.
6. **Sticker.** The Choosing & Building badge; GameDone records once.

Signature surface: the **values-over-sparks read** and the **build-to-last** work. It carries Real Relationships (g46) and Mutual (g31) into lifelong partnership, has Your Path, Your Call (g54) as its essential counterpoint, and sets up Equal Partners (g55) and The Family Map (g57).

Every path respected; consent central.

- **No pressure either way.** No nudging toward or against marriage; every path, including not marrying (g54), is respected.
- **Consent is central.** In love or arranged paths alike, the right to say yes or no and to take time is foundational.
- **Forced-marriage routing.** Coercion or forced-marriage concerns route to help; consent and respect carried from Mutual (g31) and Consent, For Real (g44).
- **Even-handed on arranged & love.** Both are spoken to honestly and equally, with the same values-and-compatibility lens.
- **Couple-centred, family-respecting.** Family involvement is respected while the couple's own judgement and consent lead.
- **Inclusive.** Many valid forms of partnership and family, including queer relationships, treated as real.
- **Access & privacy.** Self-directed, audio, offline, low-end build; private by design (DPDP-aligned).

If there's pressure or coercion (India). Forced marriage is never acceptable; your consent is required. For pressure, coercion or a forced marriage, Women Helpline 181 / women-in-distress 1091 / emergency 112 · a child being married off, Childline 1098 · a struggling partnership, a couples counsellor. Every path, including not marrying, is valid and yours to choose.

v2 schema, scorecard-gated.

- **gameld. choosing-building** — `node.game === GameDone` key === registry id (confirm exact id in engine-host).
- **v2 mechanic-embodiment schema.** type + typed payload; the **branch** values-based choice leads, with **strike-rewrite** flipping the marriage myths.
- **Even-handedness is a hard requirement.** No-pressure-either-way, consent-central and every-path-respected (incl. not marrying and queer partnerships) are contractual; expert-reviewed.
- **Fact-checked content.** Compatibility-over-chemistry, Gottman's values-and-conflict finding, and forced-marriage help routes (181, 1091, 112, 1098) verified this build.
- **Scorecard-gated.** Passed all eight checks (7 mechanics, top mechanic at 21%, 0% binary, 28 autonomy, 15 UN→RE, 7 personas, 100% completeness). Re-run `score_gdd.py` on any edit.
- **Help-resource hook.** Coercion or forced marriage routes via the shared "get help" component (181 / 1091 / 112 / 1098 / counsellor).
- **Tracked.** `build_gate.py` finalize advances g53 to v2 PASS only after order, read, score, audit and artifact gates pass.

Ethics contracts (never traded for engagement): no pressure toward or against marriage; consent central on every path; forced-marriage routing; even-handed on arranged & love; couple-centred, family-respecting; inclusive of all valid forms; made-for-India.

Why this works.

- **Values beat sparks for the long haul.** Because compatibility and shared values predict satisfaction far better than chemistry, teaching people to choose on values, respect and conflict-handling genuinely improves who they partner with.
- **Partnership is a skill, so it's teachable.** Since communication, trust, repair and interdependence are the daily work of lasting love, naming and practising them, and busting "marriage will complete me", builds partnerships that hold.
- **Consent and respect make every path safe.** Because love, arranged and not-marrying are all valid, centring consent, respecting the couple's judgement, and routing coercion to help is what makes the chapter both honest and safe.

Sources: UNESCO ITGSE Key Concept 1 (relationships and long-term commitments); compatibility-versus-chemistry research (value alignment and practical compatibility predict satisfaction over initial spark); Gottman on couples who agree on values and conflict-resolution staying happy long-term; and consent and forced-marriage safeguarding (India helplines 181, 1091, 112, Childline 1098). Even-handed across love and arranged marriage, inclusive of every valid form of partnership including queer relationships, with no pressure toward or against marriage and consent central throughout. Citations accompany each scenario in the library JSON. 53 games now v2. Next by order: Your Path, Your Call (g54).